



A New Canvas

Touted as India's answer to France's Louvre and Britain's Tate, KMoMA is all set to capture the glory of the Indian art lovers

Celebrated photographer Dayanita Singh is excited. Her work is being auctioned at Sotheby's, New York's premier auction house. "This is the first time that I have given my work for auction," she gushes. Her enthusiasm is not only shared by a host of artists, industrialists, CEOs and government officials but by the entire city.

Kolkata has its own reasons to look forward to the July 17 auction at Sotheby's. The auction, which features 90-odd works by some of India's most celebrated artists and photographers, such as Tyeb Mehta, Somnath Hore, F.N. Souza, Jehangir Sabavala, Akbar Padamsee, among others, is expected to garner between Rs 10 crore and Rs 14 crore. The money will be used for what promises to be India's biggest art hub, KMoMA. Borrowing a part of its name from the famous Museum of Modern Art (MOMA), Kolkata's art destination, christened as the Kolkata Museum of Modern Art (KMoMA), is slated to come up in 2012.

KMoMA is the brainchild of Rakhi Sarkar, owner of the Centre of International Modern Art Gallery (CIMA), who feels that space restrictions in galleries don't allow artists to do much, who have to satisfy themselves by just displaying their works. She got together a group of people, including West Bengal Chief Minister Buddhadeb Bhattacharya, senior artists Jogen Chowdhury, Paritosh Sen and Ganesh Pyne, who agreed with her. Between then and now, a committee has been formed with Bhattacharya as the chief patron, B.M. Khaitan, Chairman of Eveready

Industries as the chairperson and Sarkar as the managing trustee. The board also has names of ITC chairman Y.C. Deveshwar, West Bengal's Commerce and Industries Secretary Sabyasachi Sen, City Municipal Commissioner Alapan Bandyopadhyay, with a host of CEOs and bureaucrats.

The museum, which will be spread over 10 acre in the upcoming Rajarhat

PALETTE: Works to be auctioned on display at Sotheby's; Mehta's Kali being admired by visitors (below)

township, is looking for an international architect for its designs. The state Government had earlier allotted a five acre plot, but that was found to be inadequate to house the museum. KMoMA is planned around four major wings—an Indian art wing, a Western art section, a wing dedicated to art from the Far East and South East Asia. These will be coupled with a centre that will look after the research, conservation and academic pursuits of the museum. What is remarkable about the project is the fact that its focus is on self-sufficiency, with a little help from the state and Central governments.

The trust has targeted a budget of Rs 500 crore, whereas the actual amount for any museum of international standard is pegged around Rs 570 crore. The amount expected from the Sotheby's auction, will not even cover 2 per cent of the total cost of the museum. Chowdhury says the project is largely dependent on private participation. "We need the involvement of the Government for security and clearance purposes to make the hosting of foreign exhibitions smoother," he adds. For now, all eyes are on July 17, as that sets the tone for the project. Going by the excitement level, it seems KMoMA will be one of those projects that exemplify art for a cause. Especially when you consider that five years hence, all you would need for a world-class art experience will be a ticket to Kolkata.

by Swagata Sen



ARTISTS' OWN CHARITY

■ Sotheby's will auction some 90 works of art by 70-odd artists, including Tyeb Mehta, Somnath Hore, Jehangir Sabavala and Akbar Padamsee.

■ The proceeds of the sale, expected to be between Rs 10 to 14 crore, will go in KMoMA's kitty.

■ This will be the first time that private players and the Government will partner in a mega cultural-artistic project.